



WOVEN WORLDS Below, 'Island'; and right, 'Antrik Vishwa II', from En Route at the Bhau Daji Lad Museum

EXHIBITION ▼

CRAFTING JOURNEYS

TEXTILE AND CARTOGRAPHY UNITE TO TRACE CITIES, JOURNEYS AND FORGOTTEN HISTORIES

At the Dr. Bhau Daji Lad Museum in Mumbai, maps become more than records of geography in *En Route*, an exhibition that brings together textile, design and historical research. It examines how people, knowledge and materials move across places, using embroidery and cartographic imagery to explore ideas of travel and discovery.

BY TRANSLATING MAPS INTO TEXTILE, THE CENTREPIECE OF THE EXHIBITION SHIFTS A FAMILIAR RECORD INTO A TACTILE, HAND-CRAFTED FORM

At its centre is a work by textile artist Karishma Swali and the Chanakya School of Craft, created using the museum's rare maps documenting Mumbai's evolution. Seven layers of cartographic drawings rendered in thread refer to Heptanesia, the earliest documented name for Mumbai's seven islands as recorded by the Greek geographer Ptolemy. It traces the city's transformation through reclamation, trade and the development of its Art Deco seafront. By translating maps into textile, the work shifts a familiar record into a tactile, hand-crafted form.

En Route also brings to Mumbai works first presented at the Vatican Apostolic Library in 2025. Created by Swali and designer Maria Grazia Chiuri as a site-specific installation, they draw on the writings of six 19th-century women travellers, interpreting their journeys through maps and embroidery. Particularly evocative are two globes that showcase embroidery techniques from around the world.

Presented within the 19th-century museum, *En Route* places contemporary textile practice in conversation with the city's historical collections. ■

—Prachi Joshi

The exhibition is on till Oct. 20

GALLERY ▼

Looking East

Kolkata's original Chinatown in the heart of the city now has an art gallery celebrating its heritage

"This area was part of the 'grey town'," says G.M. Kapur of INTACH Conservation Institute, speaking about Tiretta Bazar in Kolkata, home to the newly opened Cheenapara Heritage Gallery. "While European white settlers lived in white town, Indians in black town, the grey town housed Chinese, Jewish, Armenians, and so on."

For the earliest Chinese settlers in Kolkata, this area became a socio-economic hub with five *huiguans* (native-place associations), along with temples, schools etc. "Huiguans," explains Chen Yao Hua, president of the All India Chinese Association, "functioned as a club for Chinese settlers." The Huining Huiguan, which used to house a temple, a social community hall and a dormitory, has now transformed into a gallery. "This is just one of the first steps of a greater plan for urban regeneration," says Rinkoo Bhowmik, founder of Cities Heritage and Architecture (CHA), a project that worked with INTACH to bring the gallery to fruition. The 127-year-old structure now showcases photographs of its past glory, along with displays on the 200-year-old history of the community's presence in the city. A mah-jong set, tools used in dentistry, carpentry and shoemaking workshops, along with cymbals and gongs, are also on display. Outside, a discreet red plaque with Cheenapara Heritage Gallery hand-painted in gold by Chen affixed on wrought iron brackets hints at the gallery's exhibits. ■

THE GALLERY USES OBJECTS AND IMAGES TO DEPICT 200 YEARS OF CHINESE PRESENCE



THE PAST LIVES ON The Cheenapara Heritage Gallery in Kolkata

—Malini Banerjee

The gallery is open for visits by appointment